



What Naomi Already Knew

Grade 8 • North Carolina • Reading

RL.8.6

Analyze how a gap between what the reader knows and what a character knows creates dramatic irony, and explain the humor or suspense that gap produces. An 80-minute block-period packet with warm-up, guided practice, partner discussion, independent practice, small-group work, and a full answer key.

PRINT • TEACH • REVISIT



Plan the 80-minute block

Level and alignment

Grade 8 · North Carolina · Reading; RL.8.6 — Analyze how differences in the points of view of the characters and the audience or reader (e.g., created through the use of dramatic irony) create such effects as suspense or humor.

What is included

Cover; teacher guide; vocabulary and lesson preview; original passage; warm-up (2 items); guided practice with organizer (4 items); partner discussion (3 items); independent practice (6 items); small-group intervention and enrichment (4 items); exit ticket; complete answer key; access and sources page.

Suggested pacing (80 minutes)

Warm-up 8 min · passage + guided practice 25 min · partner discussion 12 min · independent practice 20 min · small-group work 10 min · exit ticket 5 min.

Preparation

Print student pages separately from the answer key. Review the passage and organizer before class. No outside novel or paid app required.

Student directions

Read the passage carefully. Use evidence from the text to support every answer. Quote or closely paraphrase the text and name the paragraph.



Before you read

Key vocabulary

Lesson focus

Dramatic irony happens when the reader or audience knows something a character does not. The size and nature of that knowledge gap determines the effect: if the reader worries about what will happen when the truth comes out, dramatic irony creates suspense; if the mismatch itself is amusing, it creates humor.

Model 1 — In a story, the reader knows a character's "surprise" party has already been ruined by a leaked group chat, but the party planners do not know the guest of honor knows. What effect does this gap most likely create?

It most likely creates humor, since the reader can anticipate the planners' earnest, oblivious effort colliding with the guest of honor's pretending to be surprised, which is an amusing mismatch rather than a dangerous one.

Model 2 — In a different story, the reader knows a character is walking toward a meeting where they will be fired, but the character believes they are being promoted. What effect does this gap most likely create?

It most likely creates suspense or dramatic tension, since the reader anticipates a painful, consequential realization, making the character's confident anticipation uncomfortable to read rather than funny.

WARM-UP

Warm-up · Before you read

Answer using what you already know. Five minutes.

1. What explicit plan does paragraph 1 describe Marcus rehearsing?

2. What does the reader learn in paragraph 2 that Marcus does not know throughout the entire party?



What Naomi Already Knew (Part 1)

1. Marcus had planned Naomi's surprise party down to the minute: 6:45, guests arrive and hide; 6:58, Naomi's mom texts the "we're five minutes away" signal; 7:00, lights off; 7:02, Naomi walks in the door and everyone yells "surprise." He had rehearsed his own line, "Wait, what — you thought I forgot your birthday?", four times in the mirror that morning.
2. What Marcus did not know was that Naomi had been added to the party-planning group chat by accident two weeks earlier, when her cousin Deion mistyped a phone number by one digit. Naomi had read all one hundred and forty-three messages, including the argument about whether to get a bounce house (no) and Marcus's four separate drafts of his "surprise" line.
3. Naomi had told no one that she knew. Instead, she had spent the two weeks planning something of her own: a fake, elaborately bad birthday outfit — mismatched shoes, a shirt on inside out, hair deliberately disheveled — designed to make it look, when she "discovered" the surprise, like she had genuinely been caught completely off guard on her worst-dressed day.
4. At 6:58, her mother's "we're five minutes away" text arrived exactly on schedule. Naomi, sitting in the passenger seat in her deliberately disastrous outfit, felt her phone buzz and had to bite the inside of her cheek to keep from laughing at the message: "ETA 5 min, everyone in position, DO NOT respond to this text Naomi might see your phone light up."



What Naomi Already Knew (Part 2)

5. Marcus, hiding behind the couch with eleven other classmates, whispered the countdown under his breath: three, two, one. The lights were off. Someone's elbow was uncomfortably close to someone else's ear. He could hear his own heartbeat, certain this was going to be the best surprise anyone at school had ever pulled off.
6. The door opened. Naomi stepped in, took one look at the dark, silent living room, and — right on cue — let her face go slack with theatrical, wide-eyed shock a half second before the lights snapped on and thirty voices screamed "SURPRISE!"
7. She staggered back a step, hand pressed to her chest, and said, in a voice just a little too polished to be spontaneous, "Wait — is this — Marcus, did you plan this?" Marcus beamed, utterly convinced, and delivered his rehearsed line right on cue: "Wait, what — you thought I forgot your birthday?"
8. It was not until three weeks later, cleaning out her phone's message drafts, that Naomi accidentally forwarded Deion the wrong screenshot — one of her own texts from the day of the party, timestamped 6:59, that read: "putting on the worst outfit I own, wish me luck." Deion, confused, showed it to Marcus. Marcus read it twice before he understood, and then he laughed so hard he had to sit down.



Guided practice · Evidence organizer

Work through this organizer together before independent practice.

It Says Quote or closely paraphrase the text.	It Means Explain the evidence in your own words.	And So State the inference or analysis it supports.

1. At what point does the reader gain more knowledge than Marcus has? Identify the specific paragraph and explain the gap it creates.

2. What explicit plan does Naomi make in paragraph 3 once she knows about the party?

3. How does paragraph 4's detail about Naomi biting her cheek "to keep from laughing" depend on the reader already knowing what Marcus does not?

4. What does paragraph 5 reveal about Marcus's emotional state right before the surprise, and how does the reader's knowledge from paragraph 2 change how we read it?

Partner discussion

Discuss each question with a partner before writing a joint response.

1. What explicit performance does Naomi give in paragraph 6, and what word in the text signals to the reader that it is not real?

2. Identify the detail in paragraph 7 that most clearly reveals Naomi's reaction is staged, and explain why it is effective without directly stating "she was acting."

3. How does the identical repetition of Marcus's rehearsed line, from paragraph 1 to paragraph 7, contribute to the story's humor?



Independent practice

Work independently. Cite evidence from the text in every answer.

1. Where does the story's dramatic irony resolve — that is, when does a character other than Naomi finally learn what the reader has known all along?

2. How does the resolution in paragraph 8 shift the story's dramatic irony instead of ending it? Who is now in on the secret, and who might not be?

3. Compare the tone of paragraphs 5 through 7 (before Marcus learns the truth) to paragraph 8 (after he learns it). How does the dramatic irony shape each tone?



Independent practice

Work independently. Cite evidence from the text in every answer.

4. If the story had been told entirely from Marcus's point of view, without ever revealing Naomi's group-chat mishap to the reader, how would the story's effect change?

5. Explain, using at least two specific examples from the text, how this story uses dramatic irony to create humor rather than suspense.

6. What explicit detail in paragraph 2 explains exactly how Naomi ended up in the group chat?



Small-group work

Use with students who need additional support.

1. Why is it significant that Naomi "told no one that she knew" (paragraph 3), for the dramatic irony that follows?

2. What specific physical details does paragraph 3 give about Naomi's planned "disastrous" outfit?

Small-group work

Use with students ready for additional challenge.

1. How does knowing about Naomi's planned outfit (paragraph 3) change how a reader interprets her appearance when she arrives at the party in paragraph 6?

2. What single word does the narrator use in paragraph 6 that most directly tells the reader Naomi's shock is not genuine?

Exit ticket

Answer independently to show what you learned today.

1. Describe the moment where the reader's knowledge and Marcus's knowledge are furthest apart. Why is that specific moment the peak of the story's dramatic irony?



Exit ticket · self-assessment

Rate today's work:

4 — I can teach this to someone else.

3 — I can do this independently.

2 — I can do this with help.

1 — I need to revisit this with my teacher.



Answer key

1. His line for when Naomi walks in: "Wait, what — you thought I forgot your birthday?", rehearsed four times in the mirror.
2. That Naomi was accidentally added to the party-planning group chat two weeks earlier and has read all 143 messages, including Marcus's rehearsed line.
3. Paragraph 2 creates the gap; the reader learns Naomi already knows about the party, while Marcus continues believing, through paragraphs 5 through 7, that the surprise is genuine.
4. She plans a fake, elaborately bad birthday outfit designed to make her reaction look like genuine surprise on her "worst-dressed day."
5. It is only funny to the reader because they know, as Naomi does, that the "secret" text is not actually secret to her; without that earlier knowledge from paragraph 2, her reaction would not make sense.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

6. Marcus feels genuine excitement and certainty that this will be "the best surprise anyone at school had ever pulled off"; because the reader already knows the surprise is not a surprise to Naomi, his confidence creates dramatic irony rather than simple excitement.
7. She lets her face go slack with "theatrical, wide-eyed shock," and the word "theatrical" explicitly signals to the reader that her reaction is a deliberate performance, not genuine surprise.
8. The narrator describes her voice as "just a little too polished to be spontaneous," which lets the reader infer she is acting without stating it outright, reinforcing the dramatic irony already established.
9. The reader already knows from paragraph 1 that Marcus rehearsed this exact line, so hearing him deliver it "right on cue" in paragraph 7, believing it to be spontaneous, is funny precisely because the reader knows how planned and unoriginal it actually is.
10. It resolves in paragraph 8, when Marcus accidentally sees Naomi's old text and realizes she knew about the party the whole time.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

11. Instead of ending the irony, it shifts who holds the knowledge — now Marcus and the reader share full knowledge, while the rest of the party guests may still not know Naomi was never actually surprised, so a new, smaller irony gap remains.
12. Paragraphs 5–7 have a warm, earnest tone built on Marcus's sincere excitement, which the reader enjoys partly because they know something he does not; paragraph 8 shifts to a comedic tone once the gap closes and Marcus himself can finally appreciate the joke.
13. Without paragraph 2's reveal, the story would read as a simple, sincere surprise-party account with no dramatic irony; the humor specifically depends on the reader knowing what Marcus does not, so hiding that information from the reader as well would eliminate the humor entirely.
14. The gap is used for humor rather than suspense because the mismatched knowledge is low-stakes and amusing rather than dangerous — for example, Naomi biting her cheek to avoid laughing at a "secret" text she already knows about (paragraph 4), and Marcus proudly delivering a rehearsed line he believes is spontaneous (paragraph 7) — both moments make the reader smile at the mismatch rather than worry about it.
15. Her cousin Deion mistyped a phone number by one digit, accidentally adding her to the party-planning group chat two weeks earlier.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

16. It ensures the knowledge gap stays entirely between Naomi and the reader; if she had told even one other character, the irony would involve more people and would likely be discovered before the party itself.

17. Mismatched shoes, a shirt worn inside out, and hair deliberately disheveled.

18. Without that knowledge, a reader might assume Naomi simply looked disheveled from a busy day; knowing it was deliberately planned turns her appearance into part of the joke, reinforcing that her whole "surprised" persona was staged in advance.

19. "Theatrical."

20. The peak is paragraph 7, when Marcus delivers his rehearsed line "utterly convinced" while Naomi performs equally convincing fake surprise; at that exact moment, the reader alone knows both characters are performing for each other, making it the point of maximum gap between what the reader and the characters understand.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Access, sources, and license

AIG

Ask for a second interpretation, a counterexample, or a student-written item at the same rigor, with an explanation of the choice.

504

Follow the individual plan: extended time, breaks, enlarged print, reduced copying, or an alternate response method as documented.

EC

Pre-teach key vocabulary before reading. Model the first guided-practice item aloud. Accept oral or dictated responses when appropriate.

ESL

Preview key vocabulary with examples. Allow brief home-language discussion before independent writing. Provide sentence starters for open-response items.

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RL.8.6 — Analyze how differences in the points of view of the characters and the audience or reader (e.g., created through the use of dramatic irony) create such effects as suspense or humor.. The objective is original wording describing a focused part of the standard.

NC ELA Standard Course of Study, Grade 8: <https://www.thecorestandards.org/ELA-Literacy/RL/8/6/>

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